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Mayo pact alters health care terrain

R.I. collaboration brings clinical giant to region

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

The Mayo Clinic, one of the biggest names in American medicine, is pushing into New England, home turf of health care powerhouses Mass General Brigham, Yale New Haven Health, and Dana-Farber, without buying a single hospital.

Its new entry point is South County Health, a struggling hos-

pital in Rhode Island that is expected to unveil the clinical collaboration between the two next week. South County said the arrangement will give its physicians access to “world-class clinical expertise” and AI tools “at no additional cost for patients,” while keeping the hospital locally governed and owned, according to details obtained by the Globe.

South County will join the Mayo Clinic Care Network, a group of vetted independent hospitals with access to Mayo specialists, case reviews, and AI-

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With strike set, nurses and Brigham prepare for upheaval

Open-ended walkout to begin in 10 days; deal could still be reached

By Jonathan Saltzman
and Marin Wolf

GLOBE STAFF

After a bitter months-long stalemate with hospital management, the union that represents 4,000 Brigham and Women’s nurses said Friday that they will go on strike starting Oct. 14. It would be the biggest open-ended walkout by nurses in Massachusetts history.

In contrast to the one-day

strike by the Massachusetts Nurses Association at Brigham on July 8, this walkout is slated to be indefinite. That would make it far more disruptive to patients, the hospital, and nurses, who expect to forgo paychecks and lose Brigham’s contribution to their health insurance premiums.

Brigham handles an average of more than 2,000 outpatient visits per day and discharges an

average of 130 patients per day, according to Massachusetts Center for Health Information and Analysis data from 2024. Nearly 60,000 patients visited the hospital’s emergency department that year.

The nurses’ dispute is largely over wages, though the union said it is also demanding the new contract provide more affordable health insurance options and limit the hospital’s use of temporary nurses.

A long-lasting strike could wreak havoc at Brigham, a Harvard-affiliated teaching hospital

that attracts patients from around the world, and force its parent corporation, Mass General Brigham, to shell out millions of dollars for fill-in nurses. The strike date announcement came a week after union members voted overwhelmingly to authorize an indefinite walkout.

“We have repeatedly tried to get MGB to negotiate and avoid a second strike, but the billionaires who run MGB have shut the door on us,” said Kelly Morgan, a Brigham labor and deliv-

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When the water isn’t there



PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

With low levels at its reservoir along I-95, Cambridge may turn to its dry day fund

By Joshua Miller
GLOBE STAFF

WALTHAM — In a persistent drizzle, the rocky moonscape was stark: Where a large body of water should have been lapping at a tight shoreline, there were only boulders, ducks, a great blue heron, and mud — a mucky, exposed bottom land that stretched into the distance, not far from where cars were streaming along I-95.

The Hobbs Brook Reservoir has supplied the city of Cambridge with drinking water for more than a century. But depleted by a persistent drought, the largest reservoir in the city’s water system is running so low that, even with all the recent precipitation, Cambridge may soon have to buy a bunch of water.

“We’re not saving pennies for a rainy day,” said Mark Gallagher, the head of the Cambridge Water Department. “We’re sav-

ing them for a *dry* day.”

It will be an expensive day. And it could be coming soon.

I was on a tour of the city’s water system, from its reservoirs to its Fresh Pond water treatment plant, where the loud sound of mixers and pumps rang in my ears, and couldn’t help but feel lucky. Those of us who live, work, study, or play in Cambridge have a great deal: municipal tap water at a high enough quality and a low enough cost that most people don’t ever think about it.

The smooth operation of the system, however, is premised on precipitation as it used to be — not as it has become now. Storms around here are now fewer and more intense, with flash floods and flash droughts, officials say. And you can probably thank climate change.

Gallagher, the water department’s managing director, emphasized that while he’s not a climatologist nor a meteorologist, he

WATER, Page A6



The water level in the Hobbs Brook Reservoir (above on Sept. 28) is low. Cambridge officials said the reservoir was at about 20 percent of capacity. If it drops to 15 percent, the city will start buying supplemental water. Left, a gauge reflected the lower level.

2026 midterms look familiar

Voters’ feelings on president, war echo 2006

By James Pindell
GLOBE STAFF

Twenty years ago, Republicans redrew congressional maps ahead of the midterms. They used their majorities to build a

ANALYSIS huge campaign cash advantage. They told themselves the midterm elections would be OK.

Then, of course, the American public soured on the incumbent Republican president and a war in the Middle East.

In the end, the story of the 2006 midterms wasn’t that Democrats really had any organic momentum, but that independent voters bailed on the Republican Party and a big chunk of the disillusioned Republican base passed on voting at all.

It was the classic definition of a Democratic wave year. The day after, President George W. Bush analyzed the results by saying, “If you look at race by race, it was close. The cumulative effect, however, was not too close. It was a thumping.”

No one election year is a perfect comparison to another. But a month out from the 2026 midterm elections, the parallels are almost uncanny, to the point where they are a useful frame of reference for what might happen in the closing days.

First, since midterm elections are typically a referendum on the sitting president, let’s start with presidential approval ratings. Recently, The Wall Street Journal compared presidential approval ratings based on their polling with NBC News for the period between Labor Day and the midterm election going back to 1990. Next to last on the list was Bush in 2006, with a 39 percent approval rating. Dead last: Donald Trump in 2026, with 37 percent. (A more

MIDTERMS, Page A7

New York Governor Kathy Hochul appointed Attorney General Letitia James to take over the investigation of rape allegations at Cornell. **A2.**

Leaders from the Group of 7 agreed to release diesel from their stockpiles. **A3.**

Michael Minogue spent more than \$6.1 million last month in his bid to unseat Governor Maura Healey. **B1.**

A leading AI firm developing software for the legal industry is opening an office in Boston. **D1.**

Fall’s light

Saturday: Sunny, cooler. High: 65-70. Low: 50-55.

Sunday: Cloudy, breezy. High: 60-65. Low: 51-56.

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.** Obituaries, **C9.**

Citing ‘guidelines,’ T pulls ads critical of city’s schools

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

A controversy is brewing over a non-profit’s \$1.5 million campaign that posted ads on MBTA subway cars blasting Boston’s public schools, after the T yanked the ads abruptly on Thursday.

The T said the ads violated a policy in its advertising guidelines. But they were removed the day after the Globe asked questions about them, and now the campaign organizers are accusing the T of censorship.

The ads, which carried the slogan “BPS IS FAILING HER” superimposed on an image of a child’s eyes, cited state data reporting that most of Boston’s third-

graders are below grade level in math and reading.

“We can fix it, together,” the ads read. A Globe reporter spotted the ad Wednesday night on a Red Line train. After receiving inquiries about their origin, an MBTA spokesperson responded the next day that they were being removed from the T’s Orange and Red Line cars.

“These ads do not comply with the MBTA’s advertising guidelines and were placed in the system by our advertising contractor without the required MBTA review prior,” Maya Bingaman, a T spokesperson, said in an email Thursday.

The Globe sent an initial inquiry

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MARCELA RODRIGUES/GLOBE STAFF

An ad critical of Boston Public Schools was seen on a Red Line car Wednesday. The ads were removed by the T on Thursday.

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